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SEO & Search Brief

Date: Sunday, 28 June 2026

Sources checked: Search Engine Land, Search Engine Journal, Digital Applied, Momentic Marketing, Coalition Technologies, SE Roundtable (web), LLMrefs, Enrich Labs, Real Internet Sales, Digitalapplied.com, Immwit

Sources failed: SE Roundtable RSS (403 Forbidden), Google Search Blog RSS (404), Ahrefs RSS (redirect loop — followed to dead end), Marie Haynes RSS (not fetched — web search substituted)

Editor's note

Three compounding events in 48 hours. The Google June 2026 spam update completed rollout on June 26, targeting scaled AI content and thin affiliate sites specifically — the two patterns most common in programmatic SEO operations. Within two days of that completion, the Semrush Sensor spiked to 9.3 (Very High, one of the highest readings in months) with no Google announcement, suggesting either a separate unconfirmed action or severe aftermath volatility. And the Google Search Console indexing report has been dark since June 11, a 17-day gap that blinds every SEO team trying to diagnose what is actually happening. For the Orwell portfolio — pet transport, funeral repatriation, close protection, bus hire, pest control — this confluence is a material risk event. Programmatic SEO sites that publish at scale via AI content templates are the primary spam update target. The SEO Indexing Fix project loses its main diagnostic tool until GSC restores. And the Semrush Sensor says the ground is still moving.

Lead: Google June 2026 spam update complete — targeted at AI content at scale

Source: Search Engine Land |

<https://searchengineland.com/google-june-2026-spam-update-done-rolling-out-481063> | Search Engine Journal |

<https://www.searchenginejournal.com/google-begins-rolling-out-the-june-2026-spam-update/580424/> | Digital

Applied |

<https://www.digitalapplied.com/blog/google-june-2026-spam-update-rollout-site-owner-guide>

Related vault notes: [SEO Portfolio](#), [SEO Indexing Fix](#)

Google announced and completed the June 2026 spam update in a compressed two-day window: rollout began June 24 around noon ET and was marked complete on the Search Status Dashboard by June 26 at 2pm ET. This is the second spam update of 2026, following March 2026. Google characterised it as "a normal spam update" applying globally to all languages, and noted it is "a bit bigger" than the March iteration.

The update operates through improvements to SpamBrain, Google's AI-based spam-prevention system. Google explicitly confirmed the update does NOT target link spam, the site reputation abuse policy, expired domain abuse, or several other specific spam categories. This matters: it narrows the effective scope to content-based spam signals.

What the update does appear to target, based on community reporting and prior guidance:

Scaled content abuse — the highest-risk category for this portfolio. Sites publishing dozens of thin, templated AI-generated posts per week with no genuine expertise, original data, or first-person experience behind them. Google's May 2026 generative AI spam policy (covering AI Overview manipulation) is the enforcement framework that sits alongside SpamBrain.

Thin affiliate sites — pages built to capture a click and pass it on, with minimal original value at the page level.

SEO practitioners reported ranking volatility and traffic drops in the 25-50% range starting June 19, five days before the official announcement — suggesting either a pre-rollout phase or an overlapping unconfirmed sweep. The Digital Applied analysis describes "overlapping movements — the tail of a core update plus one or more unconfirmed sweeps — rather than a single discrete event." That framing is important: what the tools show as a single update may be several overlapping actions whose effects compound.

Recovery timeline: Google states that improvements can take months for its systems to reassess. There is no rapid recovery path.

Portfolio exposure assessment:

Site	Risk Level	Primary	risk factor
Pet transport	High	Programmatic at scale	AI-generated content templates
Funeral repatriation	High	Programmatic at scale	AI-generated content templates
Close protection	Moderate-High	Programmatic; lower volume but same model	
Bus hire	High	Programmatic at scale	AI-generated content templates
Pest control	High	US-targeted, USA Google US	most active enforcement

MortgageC Low- Comparison tool-led; less
reliant on
pure
content
volume

MoneyCo Low- Comparison tool-led

InsureCom Low- Comparison tool-led

The critical question is whether portfolio sites' content passes the expertise test. If articles are purely AI-generated with no proprietary data, first-person experience, or credentialed expert input, they are in the highest-risk category. The practical remediation is not to reduce publishing volume but to add layers of genuine value that SpamBrain cannot replicate: original pricing or quote data, real case studies, author credentials, first-person accounts from subject-matter experts.

Story 2: Semrush Sensor at 9.3 on June 28 — Very High volatility, no announcement

Source: Immwit |

<https://www.immwit.com/google-algorithm-updates/june-28-google-update-serp-volatility-seo-impact/> |

Digital Applied |

<https://www.digitalapplied.com/blog/google-june-2026-ranking-volatility-tracking-tool-blind-spot>

Related vault notes: [SEO Portfolio](#), [SEO Indexing Fix](#)

As of today, June 28, Semrush Sensor records 9.3 — Very High on the 0-10 scale (8-10 is Very High; algorithm update becomes statistically likely above 8). Business, food, and news categories show the largest movement. Health, travel, and local services also recording significant shifts. This is occurring less than 48 hours after the spam update completed, with no Google statement about a further action.

Three possible explanations: the June 28 spike is natural aftermath volatility from the spam update still settling into the index; it is a separate unconfirmed algorithmic sweep running in parallel; or, as Digital Applied's analysis argues, traditional volatility sensors are failing to capture some of what is happening because Google's AI Overviews and generative features are changing which content appears prominent without changing traditional blue-link rankings — making standard Sensor readings a lagging or incomplete indicator.

The health, travel, and local services categories matter for the Orwell portfolio. Pet transport sits at the intersection of travel and local services. Funeral repatriation is travel-adjacent. Close protection is local services. If those categories are seeing higher-than-normal movement, the portfolio is in the affected zone regardless of whether the cause is spam update aftermath or a separate action.

The practical implication: do not wait for rank tracker confirmation. If traffic data shows week-on-week drops in the first week of July (when GSC data should eventually catch up), treat it as spam update impact until proven otherwise.

Story 3: Google Search Console indexing report — 17-day blackout

Source: Search Engine Land |

<https://searchengineland.com/page-indexing-report-in-google-search-console-delayed-481210> | SE

Roundtable |

<https://www.seroundtable.com/google-search-console-page-indexing-report-delayed-41571.html>

Related vault notes: [SEO Indexing Fix](#), [SEO Portfolio](#)

Google Search Console's page indexing report has not updated since June 11, 2026 — a 17-day blackout at the time of writing. Google has confirmed this is a reporting delay and is not linked to the June 2026 spam update. Crawling, indexing, and ranking are unaffected; the visibility problem is in reporting only.

The operational consequence for the [SEO Indexing Fix](#) project is severe. The indexing report is the primary GSC tool for diagnosing which pages are not indexed, why, and whether fixes have taken effect. Without it:

- Cannot confirm whether sitemaps submitted since June 11 have been processed
- Cannot diagnose new indexing drops caused by the spam update (which ran June 24-26)

- Cannot verify whether any indexing fixes applied in the past two weeks have had measurable effect

The URL Inspection tool is unaffected and still works on a page-by-page basis. For targeted diagnosis of specific pages, this is the only available GSC mechanism. For portfolio-wide analysis, the only reliable alternative is external crawl tools: Screaming Frog, Ahrefs Site Audit, or Semrush Site Audit can identify indexed pages via cache checks and third-party index data.

Google has not given a restoration timeline. This is not the first time this delay pattern has occurred.

Story 4: AI Overviews cover 30-40% of queries — citation gap widens to 17-38%

Source: LLMrefs |

<https://llmrefs.com/generative-engine-optimization> | Enrich Labs |

<https://www.enrichlabs.ai/blog/generative-engine-optimization-geo-complete-guide-2026> | Real Internet Sales |

<https://www.realinternetsales.com/google-june-2026-spam-update-finished-seo-geo-ai-search/>

Related vault notes: [SEO Portfolio](#), [Comparison Network](#), [Agentic AI Keyword Forecast](#)

Google AI Overviews now appear in an estimated 30-40% of all search queries. The more structurally significant finding comes from BrightEdge and Demand Local research: the overlap between Google's top-10 organic results and the content cited in AI Overviews has fallen from approximately 75% in mid-2025 to just 17-38% in early 2026. That is a dramatic divergence in under twelve months.

What this means in practice: ranking in positions 1-10 for a query no longer guarantees appearing in the AI Overview above those results.

Conversely, a site ranked outside the top 10 can appear prominently in an AI Overview if Google's generative system selects it as the most authoritative source on that topic. Traditional SEO rank tracking — which monitors blue-link positions — is now an incomplete measure of total search visibility for any query where AI Overviews appear.

Google's official June 2026 guidance on GEO explicitly debunked several popular tactics: lms.txt is not required for AI citation; content chunking specifically for AI parsing is not recommended; rewriting content to address LLMs instead of humans is counterproductive. Google's stated position: do SEO well, write non-commodity content that genuine experts would produce, and ensure your site is crawlable by AI bots.

The most immediately actionable finding from June 2026 GEO research: **Cloudflare recently changed its default configuration to block AI crawlers.** Any site using Cloudflare's default settings — without explicit override — is now blocking Google's AI crawlers and may be completely invisible to AI Overviews without the site owner realising it. For every Orwell portfolio site and comparison network property using Cloudflare: this must be audited and corrected immediately. The fix is in Cloudflare's bot management settings — specifically, ensuring Googlebot and AI crawlers are not included in the default block list.

The confirmed GEO tactics that work as of June 2026: consistent topic cluster coverage (AI Overviews reward comprehensive coverage of a topic area, not just individual page optimisation); schema markup and structured data; being the authoritative cited source that other content references; first-party data that no one else has.

Story 5: Paid brand mentions in GEO – manipulation risk, Google now enforcing

Source: Search Engine Land |

<https://searchengineland.com/paid-brand-mention-geo-481092>

Related vault notes: [SEO Portfolio](#),
[Comparison Network](#)

Search Engine Land this week examined vendors selling paid brand placements on low-quality sites, claiming this influences LLM training data and AI citation selection. The analysis characterises this as a modern link-scheme equivalent applied to generative AI. The underlying logic is plausible – LLMs learn from the web, and what gets mentioned and cited influences what models reference – but the vendor implementations examined used spam-adjacent tactics.

Google's May 15 2026 generative AI spam policy explicitly covers manipulation of AI Overviews. The June 2026 spam update that just completed is broadly aligned with enforcement against content manufactured to game ranking systems rather than serve users — and the policy framework has now been extended to cover AI-generated search experiences, not just traditional results.

The practical note: any GEO vendor pitching paid placements on a content network to improve AI citation frequency should be treated with the same scepticism as old-school link vendors. If the placement is on a site that exists to host paid placements, it is manipulation. The legitimate GEO path is building genuine authority that AI systems recognise organically.

Story 6: Bruce Clay passes away — the father of SEO

Source: Search Engine Land |

<https://searchengineland.com/bruce-clay-the-father-of-seo-has-passed-away-481240>

Related vault notes: [SEO Portfolio](#)

Bruce Clay, widely credited as the person who coined the term "search engine optimisation" in a professional context, passed away on June 26, 2026. He founded Bruce Clay Inc. in 1996, built the first professional SEO training programmes, and contributed to SMX (Search Marketing Expo) conference development. His work defined the practitioner discipline of SEO across three decades. The passing closes the founding generation of the industry; the field that now underpins the entire Orwell SEO portfolio was named by him.

Research pipeline

- **Cloudflare AI crawler block:** immediate operational check required for all portfolio sites. Any site using Cloudflare default settings may be blocking AI crawlers and invisible to AI Overviews.
- **AI Overviews citation tracking:** establish dual monitoring — traditional rank tracker (blue links) + AI Overview monitoring (e.g. BrightEdge, custom tracking). They are now different signals.
- **Spam update content audit:** assess each portfolio site's content against "genuine expertise" criteria. AI-generated templates without original data or expert input are the primary risk.
- **SEO Indexing Fix workaround:** GSC indexing report unavailable until Google restores. Switch primary diagnostic to URL Inspection tool (page-by-page) and Screaming Frog/Semrush Site Audit (portfolio-wide).

- **GEO keyword play:** "generative engine optimisation," "AI Overview optimisation," and "GEO SEO" are rising terms with low competition. File under [Agentic AI Keyword Forecast](#).
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Market signals

- Google June 2026 spam update: completed June 26, second of 2026, targets scaled AI content and thin affiliates
- Semrush Sensor June 28: 9.3 (Very High) — no Google statement; unconfirmed action or spam update aftermath
- GSC page indexing report: dark since June 11 — 17-day blackout, no restoration timeline
- AI Overviews: appear in 30-40% of all queries
- Citation overlap (organic top-10 ↔ AI Overviews): fell from ~75% (mid-2025) to 17-38% (early 2026)

- Cloudflare default now blocks AI crawlers: all portfolio sites must be audited
- Google AI spam policy (May 15): covers AI Overview manipulation
- GEO guidance confirmed: do SEO well, structured data, topic cluster coverage — not llms.txt or LLM-specific rewriting

Open loops

Thread Status Next

milestone

Google Completed Monitor
 June 2026 June 26 portfolio
 spam site traffic
 update w/c June

29; check
 Semrush/
 Ahrefs
 rankings

June 28 Unconfirm Watch for
 Semrush ed — no continued
 Sensor Google movement
 spike (9.3) statement or Google

announce
 ment

GSC Dark since No
indexing June 11 — timeline
report 17-day from
delay blackout Google;

use URL
Inspection
and
external
crawl tools

SEO Blocked Switch
Indexing on GSC diagnostic
Fix project data toolset to

external
crawl +
URL
Inspection

Cloudflare Default Audit all
AI crawler config portfolio
block change sites for
confirmed bot-

blocking
status
immediatel
y

AI 17-38% vs Set up AI
Overviews 75% mid- Overview
citation 2025 monitoring
gap separate

from rank
tracking

Spam Not yet Portfolio-
update done level

content assessme
audit nt of

content
against
expertise
criteria

Google AI Active Monitor
spam enforceme for
policy nt manual
(May 15) actions

targeting
GEO
manipulati
on vendors

Second Volatility Stabilisatio
core throughout n
update June expected
2026 as spam
trailing update

aftermath
settles

GEO "generative File under
keyword engine
opportuniti optimisati
es on," "AI

Agentic AI
Keyword
Forecast

Overview
optimisati
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competitio
n